were ‘disgusted with the country’;[8] and some were even spreading ‘unpleasing reports’ about Akbar.[9]

This was the very year in which Akbar initiated his Ibadat Khana debates, so it isn’t hard to guess what the rumours might have been. Akbar may even have confirmed them by sending his Shia commander Husain Quli to replace Munim – and thus, incidentally, dashed his own uncle Sulaiman’s hopes of having the general escort him back to Badakhshan in triumph.[10]

When Husain Quli reached the east, its disgruntled and leaderless army had already abandoned their Bengali conquests – the old capital cities of Gaur and Tanda amongst them – and were in Bhagalpur, halfway back to Patna. The Central Asian Sunni chiefs were not happy to see their new Shia commander, mistrustful and prone to ‘chatter foolishly’[11] about him. To sweeten the deal, perhaps, Akbar also sent ‘boats laden with money and goods’. These arrived along with a man who would become even more unpopular than Husain Quli amongst the Central Asians in Bengal: the new lord of Hajipur, Muzaffar Khan.

Muzaffar Khan was now one of four broad power centres amongst the Mughals in Bihar and Bengal. The others were Todar Mal, a clan of Central Asian warlords called the Qaqshals, and their unpopular new governor, Husain Quli. Somehow these commanders managed to cobble together a working coalition. On 12 July 1576, just over three weeks after the fiercely fought battle of Haldighati, another Mughal army fought another ferocious enemy – and defeated Daud in a battle so bloody that streams of gore ‘carried away heads like polo-balls’.[12] Daud was taken prisoner, and seemed on the verge of getting a lucky truce once again. When Husain Quli asked why he had reneged on his pact with the Mughals, Daud replied cheekily that the old pact was with Munim; would Husain Quli like to make a new one?

Besides charm, Daud possessed good looks, too. Husain Quli ‘did not wish to kill him, for he was a very handsome man’, writes Badauni. It was the other commanders – having already suffered the result of trusting the fallen sultan, perhaps – who persuaded him to do so. For all that Daud had failed to keep his father’s throne, he showed himself capable of a noble death. When he asked for water, writes Badauni, an unkind Mughal soldier brought it to him in his slipper. Defeated but dignified, Daud refused, and